Brian Butler

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FREE CHECKLIST

The Home Seller's Preparation Checklist

A room-by-room, week-by-week guide to getting market-ready.

Serving Arizona, specializing in San Tan Valley & Florence.

Why Preparation Matters

How a home is prepared can make a real difference in how buyers respond to it. This checklist walks through what to do before listing, organized by timeline.

You don't need a major renovation. Focused effort on the right things matters more than spending a lot. When we meet, I'll tell you what is worth doing in your home and what isn't.

Phase 1: Declutter and Depersonalize (2 to 4 Weeks Before Listing)

Buyers need to picture their own life in your space, which is hard when they're looking at your family photos, collections, and clutter.

- [ ] Remove personal photos, religious items, and political decor so the home has the broadest appeal.
- [ ] Clear kitchen counters of everything except one or two decorative items.
- [ ] Declutter closets. Buyers will open them. Aim for them to look roomy.
- [ ] Clear out the garage so buyers can see usable space.
- [ ] Remove excess furniture so rooms feel larger.
- [ ] Pack up seasonal items and anything you won't need before the move.
- [ ] Consider a small storage unit for overflow.

Phase 2: Deep Clean (1 to 2 Weeks Before Listing)

A spotless home signals that it's been cared for. A dirty one makes buyers wonder what else has been neglected.

- [ ] Consider a professional deep cleaning.
- [ ] Clean all windows inside and out. Natural light helps.
- [ ] Steam clean or replace worn carpet.
- [ ] Scrub grout in bathrooms and the kitchen.
- [ ] Clean light fixtures and ceiling fans. Arizona dust builds up fast.
- [ ] Wipe down baseboards, door frames, and light switches.
- [ ] Clean the oven, dishwasher, and other appliances inside and out.
- [ ] Check for pet odors. You may be used to them, so ask a friend to be honest.

> **Brian's Tip:** In Arizona, dust is relentless. Plan to dust and vacuum often while your home is on the market, especially during monsoon season.

Phase 3: Repairs and Touch-Ups (1 to 2 Weeks Before Listing)

Fix the small stuff. Buyers notice flaws, and small issues make them wonder about bigger ones.

- [ ] Fix leaky faucets and running toilets.
- [ ] Repair or replace cracked or broken tile.
- [ ] Touch up paint: scuffs, nail holes, and high-traffic wear. Neutral colors photograph and show best.
- [ ] Replace burned-out bulbs and use consistent, warm-white bulbs throughout.
- [ ] Fix doors that stick, squeak, or don't latch.
- [ ] Repair or replace damaged window screens.
- [ ] Re-caulk around tubs, showers, and sinks where old caulk has yellowed or cracked.
- [ ] Address any obvious AC issues. Arizona buyers will test the AC right away.
- [ ] For an older home, ask me about a pre-listing inspection so you can address issues before buyers find them.

Phase 4: Curb Appeal (1 Week Before Listing)

Buyers form their first impression before they walk through the door. In Arizona, curb appeal is its own thing.

- [ ] Clean up desert landscaping: trim bushes, remove dead plants, and refresh rock or gravel areas.
- [ ] Edge walkways and driveways.
- [ ] Power wash the driveway, sidewalks, and patio.
- [ ] Paint or replace a tired front door. It's one of the most visible and affordable upgrades.
- [ ] Update house numbers and the mailbox if they look dated.
- [ ] Add a few potted plants or desert-friendly flowers near the entry.
- [ ] Clean the garage door. It's one of the largest visible surfaces on your home.
- [ ] Make sure exterior lighting works and looks inviting for evening showings.

Phase 5: Stage and Photograph (Listing Week)

- [ ] Consider professional staging. At minimum, follow the decluttering steps above.
- [ ] Professional photography matters. Most buyers start their search online, and photos are their first showing.
- [ ] Open all blinds and turn on all lights for the photo shoot.
- [ ] Add fresh towels in the bathrooms and a fresh throw on the couch.
- [ ] Put out a few fresh flowers or a bowl of fruit. Small touches add up.
- [ ] Set the AC to a comfortable temperature for showings. Buyers notice.

During Showings: Quick Checklist

- [ ] Leave during showings. Buyers are more comfortable without the seller present.
- [ ] Make beds, clear dishes, and tidy up before every showing.
- [ ] Secure valuables, medications, and personal documents.
- [ ] Take pets with you or arrange for them to be elsewhere.
- [ ] Leave lights on and blinds open.

- [ ] Set the AC to a comfortable temperature before you leave.

Want a Walkthrough of Your Home?

I'll walk through your home with you at no cost or obligation and tell you what's worth doing and what isn't. I can also put together a free home value analysis based on recent sales near you at thebutlerrealty.com/home-value.

480-810-9255 • Brian@thebutlerrealty.com • thebutlerrealty.com

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